

Your off site SEO audit, and what to do next.

This off site audit looks at what search engines see beyond the Client's own website. It covers the backlink profile and its health, how the Client compares with nine competitors, the referring domains and link opportunities worth pursuing, and the search terms where competitors currently win. It sets out where the Client stands today and the four priorities for the next phase.

Findings drawn from a Semrush snapshot taken on 22 September 2026, UK market, across National Fostering Group and its nine closest competitors.

Strong on the page, thin off the page.

The Client punches well above its weight on the searches that bring in enquiries. The catch sits underneath: the link base that search engines use to judge trust is small and very new. Here are the four headline numbers, each with how the Client places among the ten fostering websites we benchmarked.

Authority Score

36

A trust rating from 0 to 100. Above the competitor middle of 29.

Ranks 2 of 10

Referring domains

420

Separate websites that link to the Client. The competitor middle is about 820.

Ranks 9 of 10

Organic traffic

15,906

Estimated monthly visits from unpaid search. Near the top of the set.

Ranks 2 of 10

Organic keywords

4,028

Distinct search terms the Client ranks for in the UK.

Ranks 2 of 10

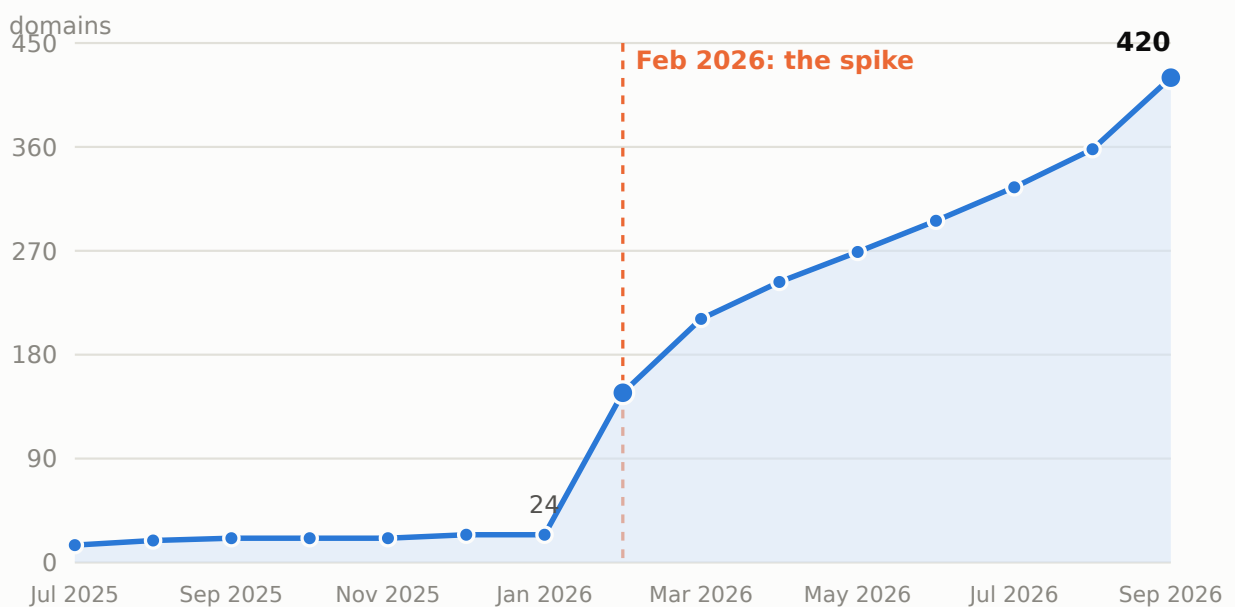
Read together, these tiles tell one story. On visibility and traffic the Client sits second only to the sector body theFosteringNetwork. On the count of websites linking in, it sits second from bottom. That single gap, off the page rather than on it, is what the rest of this report is about.

A young and risky backlink profile.

A healthy link profile grows steadily over years and leans on trusted, relevant sites. The Client's did neither. It was flat for years, then jumped almost vertically, and much of what arrived carries the fingerprints of bought links.

Referring domains over time

Separate websites linking to the Client, month by month. The profile was negligible until February 2026, then spiked.



The dashed guide marks February 2026, where the count jumped from 24 to 147 in a single month.

► [View data table](#)

The Client's profile existed since 2024, but it was tiny: about **24 referring domains** right through to January 2026. Then it spiked to 147 in February 2026 and reached 420 by September. Roughly **94 percent of the 420 referring domains were acquired in the last 8 months**. A near vertical rise like this is the signature of an aggressive, bought campaign rather than earned reputation.

Why this matters

The high Authority Score of 36 is riding on that recent surge, not on a broad, earned base. Growth bought this quickly can be discounted by search engines later, so the score is more fragile than it looks.

Three toxicity signals stand out

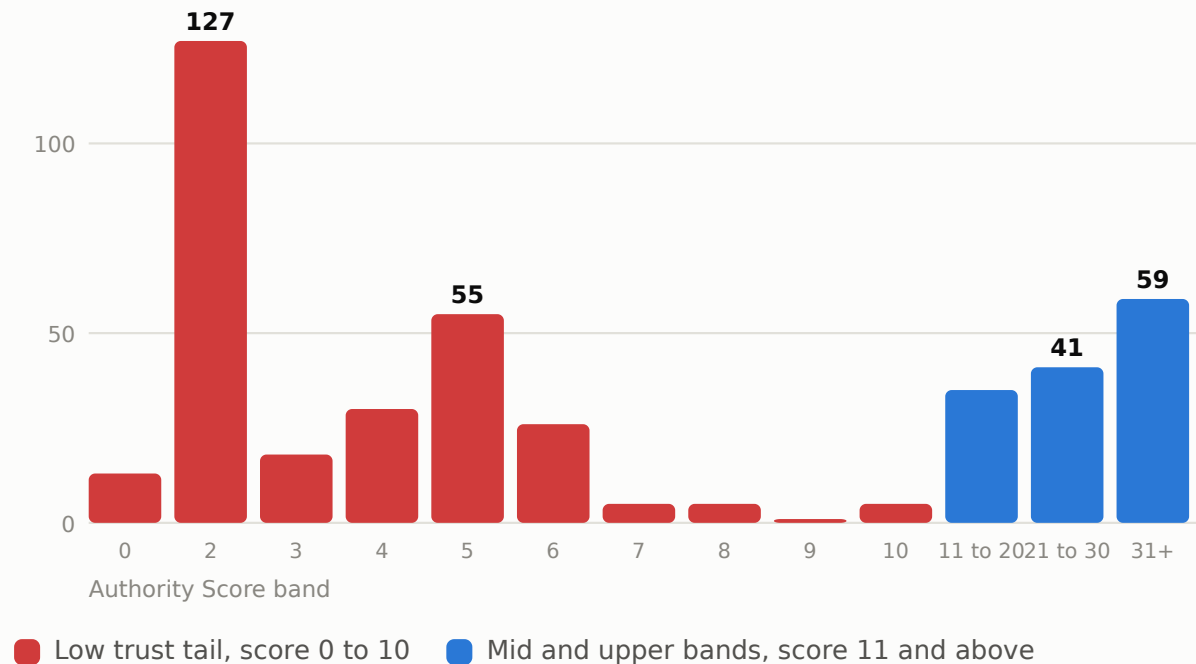
A heavy low quality tail. About **67 percent** of the referring domains sit in the lowest trust band, Authority Score 0 to 10. The competitor middle is around 54 percent, so the Client carries an unusually large weak tail.

Live link buying anchors. More than 80 referring domains carry link text that openly advertises paid schemes, for example offers of premium private blog network links and safe link velocity. That is a direct paid link footprint, not organic mentions.

Address clustering. Around 42 domains, roughly one in ten, share just two IP addresses, and a further 23 sit on a single Singapore subnet. Sharing addresses at this rate is a classic private blog network pattern, and it lines up in time with the February spike.

Referring domains by trust band

How the Client's links spread across Authority Score bands. A healthy profile tapers like a pyramid. This one spikes in the weakest band.



Handle the clean up carefully, not with a blunt tool

Roughly **84 referring domains** are clear candidates to disavow now. A wider group of about **127 low trust domains** should be reviewed by hand first, not removed automatically, because some carry genuine local council, charity or news value that is worth keeping. Disavow is a scalpel here, not a hammer.

The Client already wins the commercial searches.

On the terms that turn into enquiries, the money terms, the Client is already strong. The real opening is elsewhere: high volume informational searches where the Client does not appear at all, but competitors do.

The Client owns the commercially valuable terms. It ranks at **position 4** for "fostering agencies", **position 5** for "foster carer salary", **position 9** for "become a foster carer", and top of the page for the high intent question "how much do foster parents get paid". These are the searches a prospective carer runs when they are close to enquiring, and the Client is visible on them.

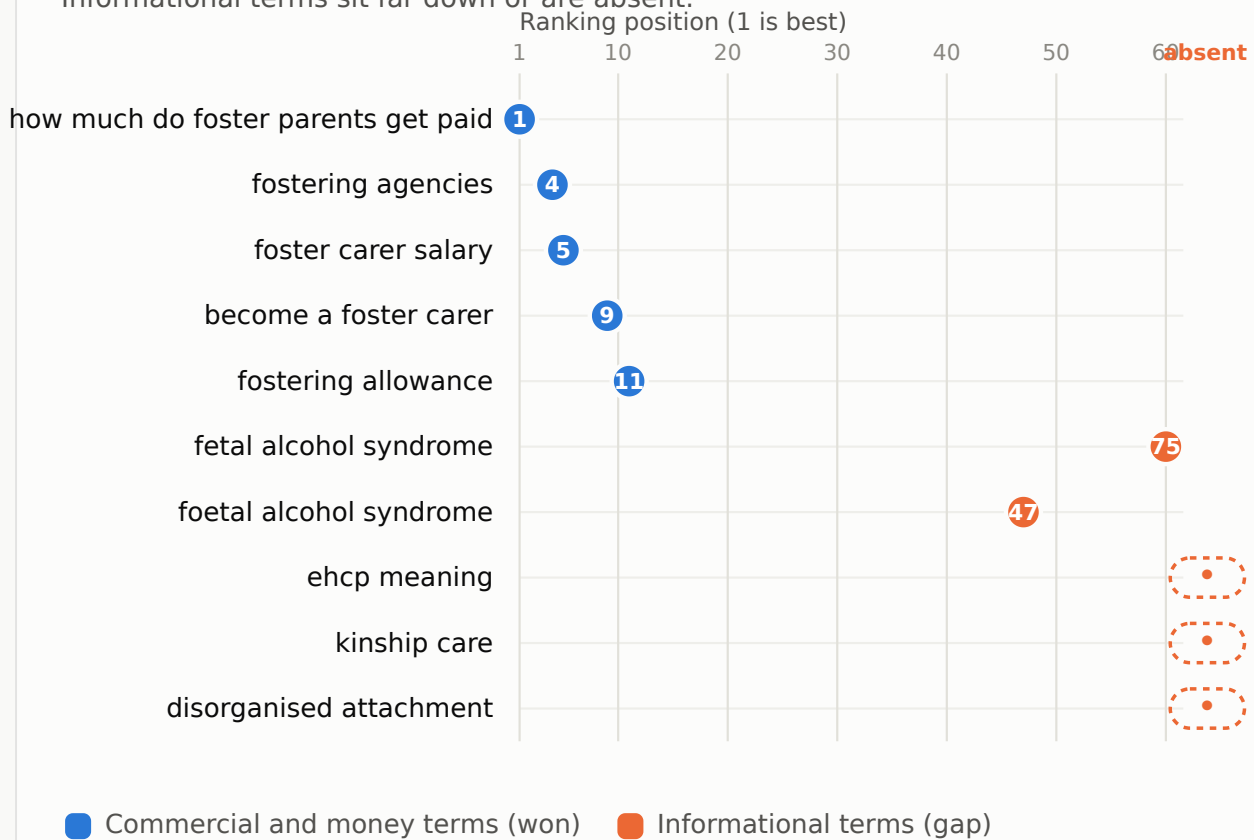
Where the Client is missing is the informational layer: the questions people ask earlier in their journey, long before they pick an agency. Those searches are large, winnable, and almost entirely unclaimed by the Client today.

What it means

The next content investment should go into informational topics, not more money term pages. The money terms are close to won. The informational demand is open ground that also builds the topical authority the whole site needs.

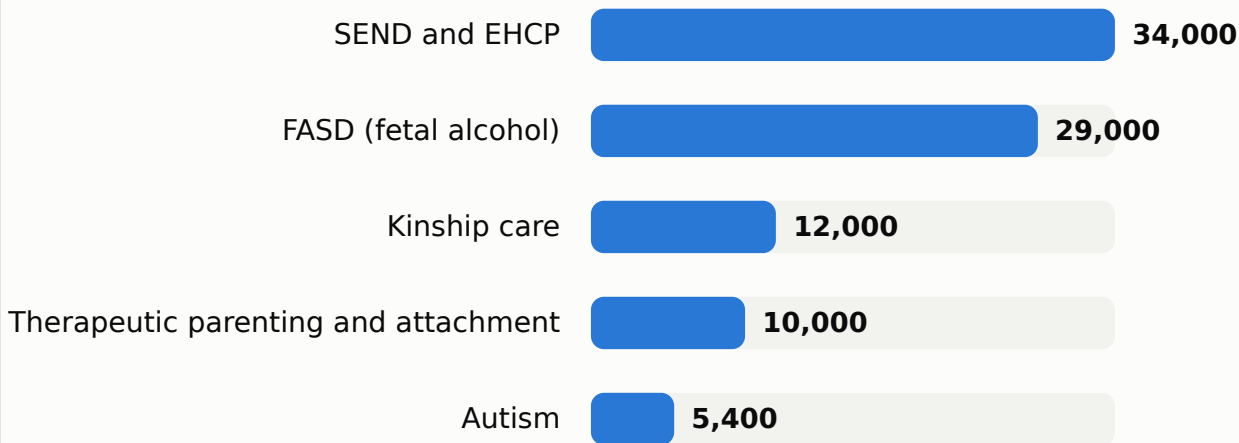
Where the Client sits, by search intent

Each marker is a headline search term, placed by the Client's ranking position. Lower positions, further left, are better. Commercial terms cluster near the top of results. Informational terms sit far down or are absent.



The open opportunity: monthly UK searches the Client does not rank for

Informational clusters where competitors already appear and the Client does not.
Figures are approximate combined monthly search volume.



Every cluster here is proven winnable: at least one competitor already ranks on the first page for terms inside it.

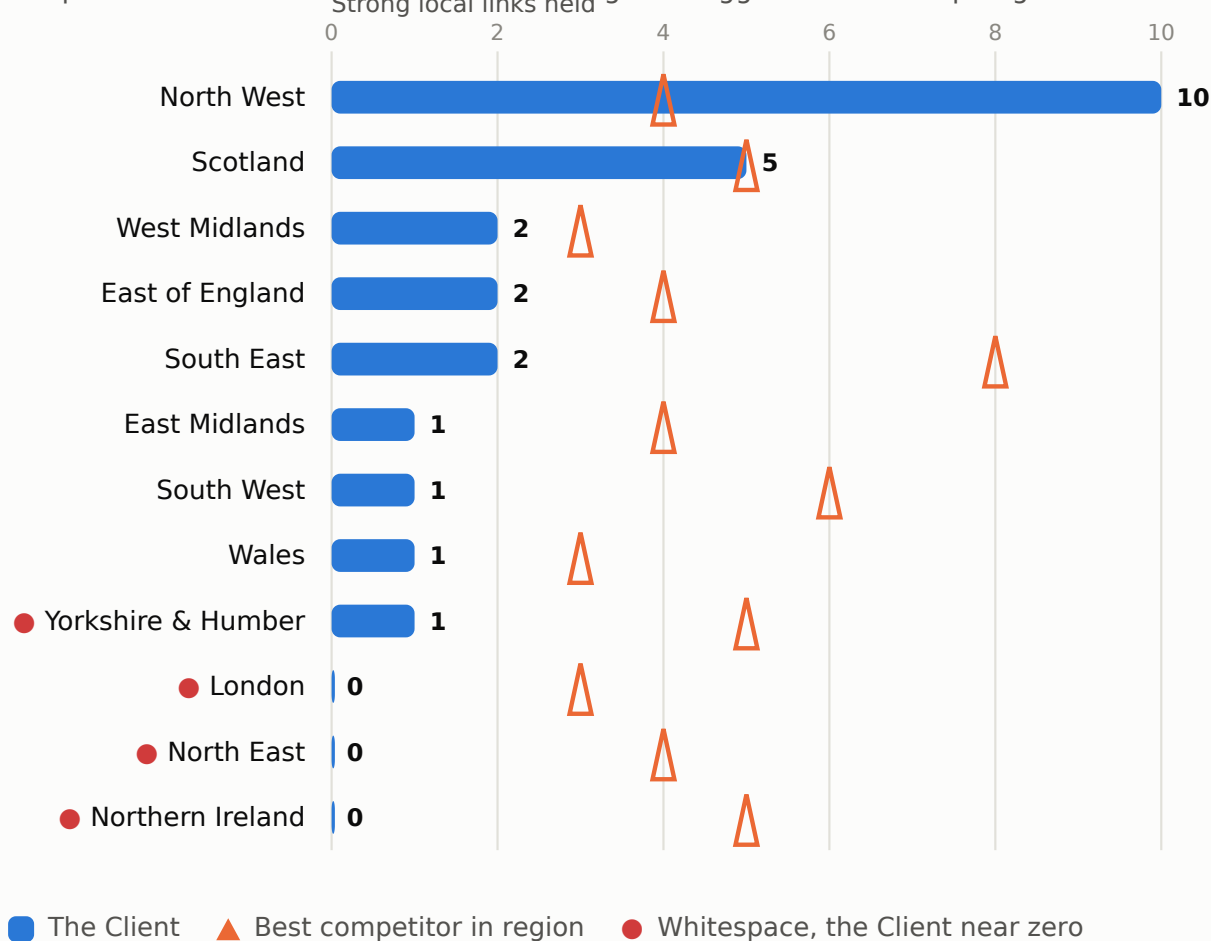
[► View data table](#)

Where the Client is invisible: the regions.

Fostering demand is deeply local, and links from local news, councils and universities carry real weight. The Client is strong in a couple of regions and absent in others that competitors have already proven reachable, including places the Client genuinely operates.

Regional link strength: the Client versus the best competitor

Count of the Client's strongest local links per UK region, with the best single competitor's count marked for reference. Regions flagged below are open ground.



► [View data table](#)

The Client leads in the **North West** with ten strong local links, and holds **Scotland** with five. But it has **nothing in the North East** and only a single link in **Yorkshire and Humber**. Both of those regions are proven attainable: the

sector bodies theFCA and theFosteringNetwork hold four to five local links each there.

Crucially, both gaps sit inside the Client's real service geography. **NFA North** covers Yorkshire and Lincolnshire, and **Reach Out Care** covers the North East and Cumbria. So local pages and outreach here would rest on genuine on the ground presence, not thin doorway pages.

A starter set of regional targets already linking to competitors:

chroniclelive.co.uk · North East

sunderlandecho.com · North East

leeds.ac.uk · Yorkshire

leeds.gov.uk · Yorkshire

hulldailymail.co.uk · Yorkshire

newcastleworld.com · North East

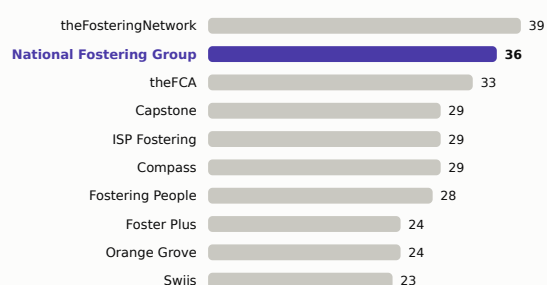
How the Client compares.

The same ten fostering websites, ranked on the four measures that matter. The Client, shown in indigo, is top tier on three of them and last but one on the fourth. That fourth measure, referring domains, is the whole story in one picture.

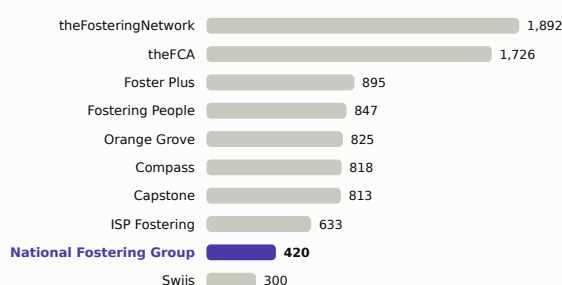
The four measures across all ten websites

Each panel ranks the ten websites on one measure. The Client is highlighted in indigo, competitors in grey. Hover any bar for the exact figure.

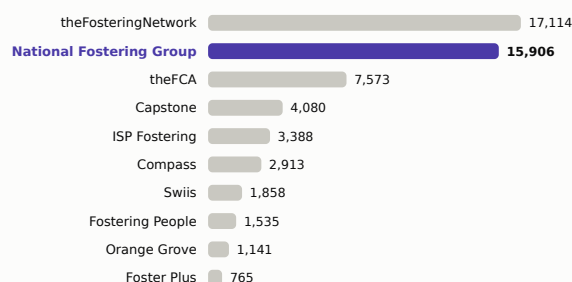
Authority Score (0 to 100)



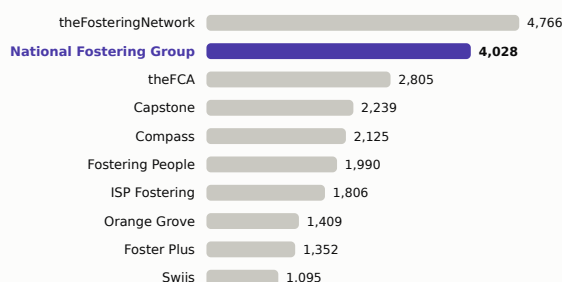
Referring domains



Organic traffic (monthly visits)



Organic keywords

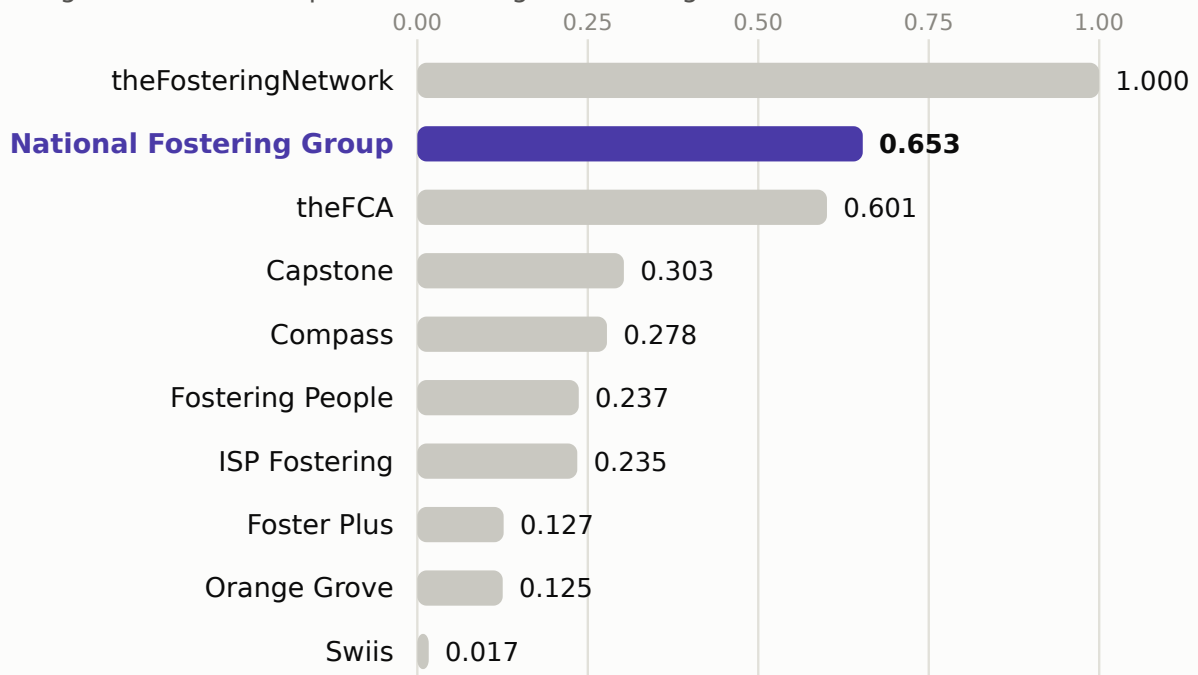


Organic traffic is estimated monthly visits from unpaid search. Referring domains counts the separate websites that link in.

► [View data table](#)

Composite strength, all four measures combined

A single blended score per website. Higher is stronger overall.



Reading the composite

Composite strength is the average of the four Semrush measures, each rescaled to a 0 to 1 range across the ten websites, so no single large number dominates. The Client scores **0.653**.

Underneath that headline, the Client is strong on Authority Score (0.81), Organic Keywords (0.80) and Organic Traffic (0.93), but very weak on Referring Domains (0.08). Three strong pillars and one weak one. That one weak pillar is the deficit, and closing it is the highest leverage work available.

What the next phase should focus on.

Four moves follow directly from the findings. They are sequenced so the defensive clean up protects the base while the growth work builds on it. Together they turn a fragile, narrow profile into a durable one.

MOVE 01

Clean the link base, with a scalpel

Disavow the roughly 84 clear spam domains, then review the wider set of about 127 low trust domains by hand before touching them. This protects the Client from the risk built into February's spike without discarding genuine local and charity links.

Defensive · do first

MOVE 02

Earn real regional links in Yorkshire and the North East

Target local news, councils and universities such as [chroniclelive.co.uk](https://www.chroniclelive.co.uk), [leeds.ac.uk](https://www.leeds.ac.uk) and [leeds.gov.uk](https://www.leeds.gov.uk), anchored to genuine presence through NFA North and Reach Out Care. This closes the clearest regional whitespace and grows the referring domain count that the composite score depends on.

Highest leverage

MOVE 03

Build the SEND and EHCP information hub

Create genuinely useful content around SEND and EHCP, about 34,000 searches a month, and extend it into FASD, kinship care and therapeutic parenting. This captures large, winnable informational demand and builds the topical authority the whole site benefits from.

MOVE 04

Fix the fostering allowance quick win

The term "fostering allowance" sits at position 11, just off page one, with two competing Client pages splitting the signal. Consolidate them onto one clear page and add internal links. A small fix on a term the Client nearly owns already.

Quick win

In short: the Client has earned strong visibility and already wins the searches that convert. The base underneath it is young and needs both protecting and broadening. Do the clean up, widen the regional link base where the Client genuinely operates, and open up the informational demand it is currently missing. Those three things compound, and the quick win pays for itself in weeks.